Two-Stage Pretraining Data Curation: Forging 120B-Token Foundation Intelligence and Precision Annealing for Compact Language Models

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Enigmare AI Research · Technical Report No. 02

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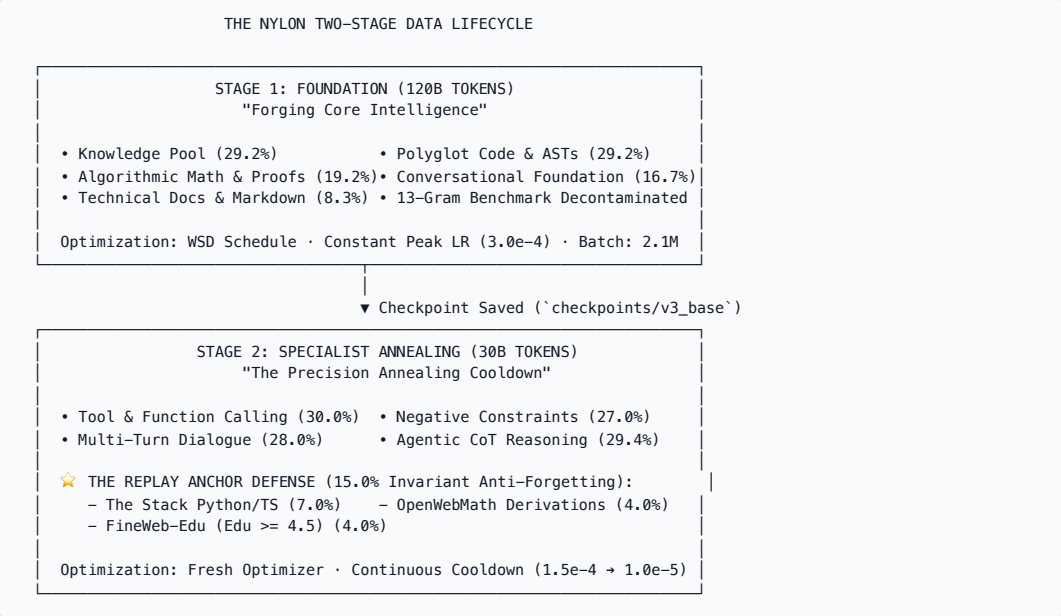
Abstract

In compact autoregressive language models ($\leq 1.5\text{B}$ parameters), representational capacity is a scarce, strictly bounded resource. Standard industrial pretraining treats data as a monolithic, single-pass web scrape where general language, code, conversations, and tool syntaxes are mixed haphazardly from step zero. We demonstrate that this naive paradigm severely impairs compact models by inducing premature representational collapse and catastrophic forgetting.

We present the **Nylon Two-Stage Pretraining Data Curation Architecture**, a co-designed data and optimization framework that decouples pretraining into two distinct regimes:

1. **Stage 1: Forging Foundation Intelligence (120 Billion Tokens):** Sourced across a balanced six-pool curriculum (educational prose, polyglot syntax trees, LaTeX mathematical derivations, and technical Markdown). All formatting, special markup tokens, and dialogue constraints are strictly excluded, allowing the model's self-attention layers to spend 100% of their early parameter budget learning core semantic primitives, grammar, world knowledge, and algorithmic logic. Data is processed through an 8-stage curation pipeline incorporating 128-permutation MinHash LSH deduplication at $J \geq 0.85$ and 13-gram rolling benchmark decontamination.
2. **Stage 2: Specialist Annealing (30 Billion Tokens):** Following base foundation training, the model enters a precision annealing phase. The learning rate cools down continuously from 1.5×10^{-4} to 1.0×10^{-5} under a fresh optimizer state (`weights_only: true`), during which the model is flooded with high-density tool-calling trajectories (30.0%), strict negative instruction constraints (27.0%), and multi-turn human dialogues (28.0%).
3. **The 15% Replay Anchor Defense:** To prevent catastrophic forgetting of foundational mathematical logic and polyglot code during the dramatic distribution shift of annealing, we mathematically enforce that 15.0 of the annealing token diet consists of invariant replay anchors spanning curated Python/TypeScript, OpenWebMath, and FineWeb-Edu ($\text{score} \geq 4.5$).

The entire pipeline is declaratively governed through human-readable YAML specifications that serve as the single source of truth across ingestion, filtering, binary `uint16` sharding, and multi-GPU distributed execution.



1. Introduction: The Two-Stage Pretraining Philosophy

Modern frontier artificial intelligence research has spent hundreds of millions of dollars scaling parameter count to brute-force comprehension over noisy, uncurated internet scrapes. In trillion-parameter systems ($N \geq 405\text{B}$), the parameter overcapacity is vast enough that models can absorb noise, forum flame wars, and arbitrary markup syntax without immediately degrading their core mathematical or coding logic.

However, in **compact language models** ($N \approx 500\text{M} - 1.5\text{B}$ parameters), parameter capacity is strictly bounded. Every single layer, attention head, and feed-forward activation must be utilized with surgical efficiency.

When a compact model is trained on a monolithic mixture containing chat templates, tool markup (`<|tool_call|>`), and conversational chit-chat from step zero, it encounters a catastrophic dilemma: **it wastes parameter capacity learning superficial formatting rules before it understands the underlying mechanisms of logic and reality.**

1.1 The Intuitive Analogy: Medical School vs. Surgical Residency

To understand why single-pass training fails, consider the education of an elite neurosurgeon:

- **The Naive Approach (Monolithic Training):** If an 8-year-old child is placed inside an operating room on Day 1 and taught how to hold a scalpel, talk to patients, and fill out surgical consent forms, they do not become a genius surgeon. They become an actor mimicking surface gestures. They have no understanding of human anatomy, cellular biochemistry, or neuro-pathology. When an unexpected complication arises, they fail catastrophically.
- **The Nylon Approach (Two-Stage Co-Design):**
  - **Stage 1 (Medical School):** The student spends years in an intensive, distraction-free environment studying biology, organic chemistry, pathology, and mathematics. They do not worry about hospital administrative forms or bedside chit-chat. Their brain constructs rich, deep representations of the scientific laws governing human anatomy.
  - **Stage 2 (Surgical Residency):** Only after the foundational representation is forged does the resident enter clinical immersion. They are flooded with surgical tools, strict operating room negative constraints (*"Do NOT touch this artery"*), and multi-turn patient consultations.
  - **The Replay Anchor Insurance:** Crucially, while in surgical residency, the resident does not discard their medical textbooks. A deliberate percentage of their weekly routine remains anchored in scientific literature so their foundational biochemistry knowledge never decays.

1.2 The Metallurgical Principle: Why It Is Called "Annealing"

In physical metallurgy, **annealing** is a heat-treatment process where a metal is heated above its recrystallization temperature, held at that state to allow internal dislocations to migrate, and then **cooled at a controlled, gradual rate**.

- If metal is forged and cooled instantaneously (quenching), internal stresses freeze in place, rendering the blade brittle and prone to catastrophic cracking.
- If metal is heated indefinitely without controlled cooling, crystalline grains grow uncontrollably coarse, losing all hardness and cutting retention.

In neural network optimization:

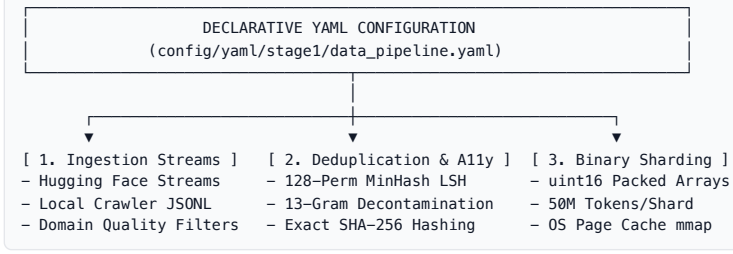
- **Stage 1 (Forging):** We maintain the network at a constant, high thermodynamic state (a stable peak learning rate $\eta = 3.0 \times 10^{-4}$ over 120 billion tokens). The weights remain highly plastic, exploring broad loss basins and acquiring general representations of human language, polyglot programming syntax, and mathematical reasoning.
- **Stage 2 (Annealing):** We deliberately lower the optimization temperature, decaying the learning rate continuously from 1.5×10^{-4} down to 1.0×10^{-5} across the annealing budget. Simultaneously, we change the data distribution from general knowledge to high-density tool-calling schemas and complex reasoning. Under this controlled cooling, the model's weights settle into sharp, highly specialized minima that master tool syntax without shattering the broad foundational intelligence forged in Stage 1.

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2. Declarative Data Architecture: The YAML Engine as Single Source of Truth

In large-scale data engineering, a pervasive failure mode is the decoupling of configuration from operational execution: crawler parameters live in environment variables, tokenizer configurations live in shell scripts, and training dataloaders parse hardcoded paths.

Nylon eliminates this divergence by establishing **Declarative YAML Configurations as the single source of truth** across the entire lifecycle.



2.1 The Data Pipeline Configuration Schema

The architecture is parsed through strongly-typed dataclasses defined in [`llm/data_pipeline/config.py`](file:///Users/engmare/personal-projects/crawler/llm/data_pipeline/config.py). The configuration strictly governs nine operational dimensions:

```yaml
corpus:
  name: "stage1_foundation_120b"
  target_tokens: 120000000000          # 120 Billion Token Target
  min_tokens_required: 108000000000    # 90% Floor Threshold

quality_policy:
  never_pad_with_low_quality_data: true
  allow_underfill: true                # Prefer smaller corpus over duplicate looping
  report_actual_tokens: true

split:
  train: 0.9975                        # 119.7B tokens for pre-training
  val: 0.00125                         # 150M tokens for validation
  test: 0.00125                        # 150M tokens for benchmark evaluation

tokenizer:
  path: "models/v3/tokenizer"
  vocab_size: 65536                    # Exact 16-bit boundary (0..65535)
  dtype: "uint16"                      # Native 2-byte serialization
  split_digits: true
  code_indentation_runs: true

sharding:
  tokens_per_shard: 50000000           # 50M tokens (~100MB per binary file)
  output_base_dir: "data/shards/stage1"
  num_workers: 8

deduplication:
  exact_hash: true
  minhash_lsh: true
  minhash_threshold: 0.85              # 85% Jaccard similarity cutoff
  shingle_size: 5
  num_perm: 128                        # 128 permutation hashes

decontamination:
  check_contamination: true
  n_gram_size: 13
  benchmark_sets:
    - "openai/openai_humaneval"
    - "google-research-datasets/mbpp"
    - "openai/gsm8k"
```

2.2 The "Never Pad" Quality Directive

A cornerstone of our curation philosophy is encoded in the `quality_policy` directive:

```yaml
never_pad_with_low_quality_data: true
allow_underfill: true
```

Traditional training pipelines often loop over low-quality data or pad batches with repeated text simply to hit an arbitrary target token round number. In compact models, **repeated data cycles over-index on specific subword sequences, causing gradient spikes and memorization loops**. Nylon enforces a strict *Underfill Policy*: if a high-quality dataset

produces 112 billion clean tokens instead of 120 billion, training executes on the verified 112 billion tokens rather than diluting the distribution with synthetic filler or duplicate iterations.

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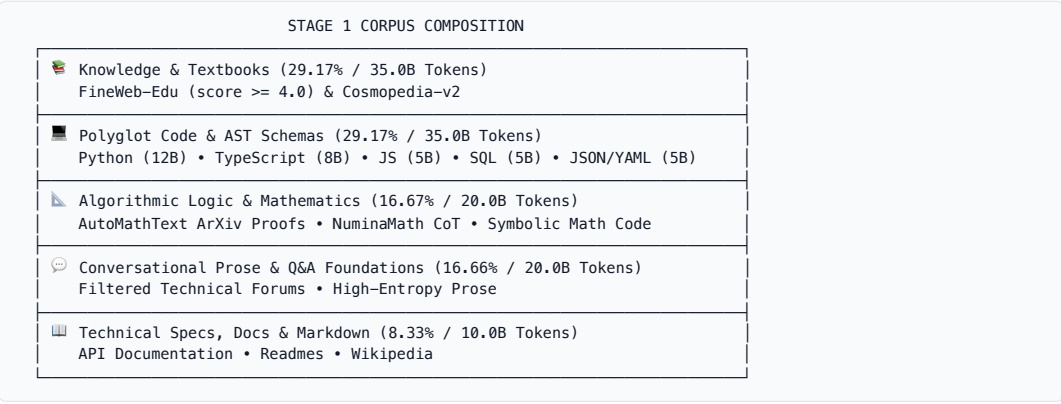
3. Stage 1: Forging Foundation Intelligence (120B Tokens)

The objective of Stage 1 is the acquisition of broad linguistic competence, syntactic understanding, polyglot code fluency, and mathematical reasoning.

3.1 Corpus Mixture Formulation

The Stage 1 corpus is distributed across six balanced pools totaling 2,400 binary shards:

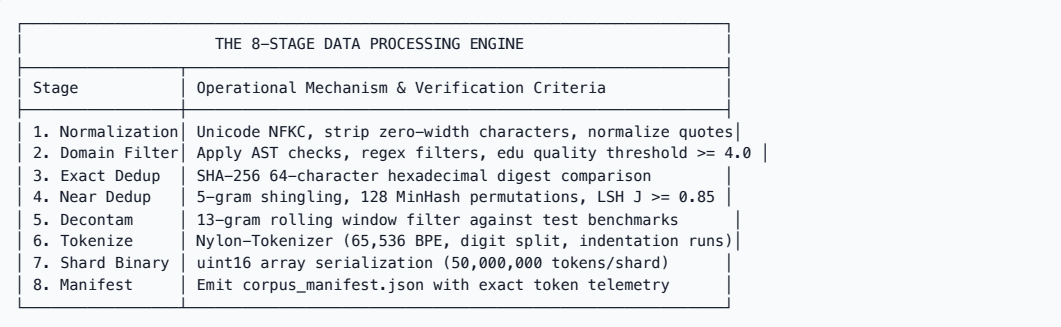
Pool ID	Domain / Focus	Target Tokens	Mixture Share	Primary Sub-Sources & Filtering Criteria
Pool 1	**Curated Knowledge & Science**	**35.0 Billion**	**29.17%**	FineWeb-Edu (score ≥ 4.0, 20.0B), Cosmopedia-v2 (15.0B synthetic textbooks).
Pool 2	**Polyglot Code & AST Schemas**	**35.0 Billion**	**29.17%**	The Stack Dedup (Python: 12B, TypeScript: 8B, JavaScript: 5B, SQL: 5B, JSON/YAML schemas: 5B).
Pool 3	**Algorithmic Math & Proofs**	**20.0 Billion**	**16.67%**	AutoMathText ArXiv (score ≥ 0.50, 12B), NuminaMath CoT (5B), AutoMath Python (3B).
Pool 4	**Conversational Foundations**	**20.0 Billion**	**16.66%**	C4 RealNewsLike (10.0B), FineWeb Filtered Technical Q&A Forums (10.0B).
Pool 5	**General Reference & Specs**	**10.0 Billion**	**8.33%**	Wikipedia EN (3.0B clean references), Repository Markdown & API specs (7.0B).
Pool 6	**Scientific OpenWebMath**	**3.0 Billion**	**2.50%**	Open-Web-Math peer-reviewed scientific discussions and STEM derivations.



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4. The 8-Stage Curation & Verification Pipeline

Every raw document ingested by the system passes through eight sequential, deterministic processing stages prior to tokenization:



4.1 Lessons from the Legacy Scrape Post-Mortem

The architecture of our Stage 1 pipeline was forged directly from empirical failure modes observed during earlier baseline trials. In an audit of a 178-million-token scraped Dev.to legacy corpus ([`MODEL_FINDINGS.md`](file:///Users/engmare/personal-projects/crawler/docs/trainer/MODEL_FINDINGS.md)), we discovered three structural anomalies that severely contaminated model completions:

1. **DOM UI Artifact Poisoning:** Scraped HTML buttons leaked inline text directly into sentences:
$$\text{"Docker Containerization Guide ... AddComment 2minread loading..."}$$
2. **Author Metadata Repetition:** Unparsed user profile elements created pathological loops:
$$\text{"Jess Lee Jess Lee Jess Lee Parsa Jiravand Parsa Jiravand..."}$$
3. **Whitespace Flattening & BPE Boundary Collapse:** Stripping paragraph breaks ($\backslash n \backslash n$) collapsed inter-word boundaries. When subword BPE tokenization was applied, adjacent words fused into illegible compounds:
$$\text{"thatitprovidesasignificantbarrierto..."}$$

To permanently resolve these defects, Stage 1 abandons regex-based HTML cleaning in favor of **AST-Aware Extraction**:

- Syntax trees parse Markdown structure explicitly, preserving double linebreaks ($\backslash n \backslash n$) around paragraphs, headers, and code fences.
- The generator incorporates **Incremental Text Delta Decoding** (`current_text[len(last_text):]`), guaranteeing that word-boundary spacing is never dropped across UTF-8 streaming boundaries.

4.2 Mathematical Deduplication: Multi-Tier Hashing

Deduplication operates across two coordinated mathematical layers:

Exact Binary Match (Stage 3)

A fast SHA-256 hash digests the normalized text:

$$h_{\text{exact}} = \text{SHA-256}(T_{\text{norm}})$$

Collisions discard identical document copies with $\mathcal{O}(1)$ lookup time.

MinHash Locality-Sensitive Hashing (Stage 4)

For documents that differ by minor variations (e.g., license headers, timestamps, tracking tags), we compute the **Jaccard Similarity** over word k-shingles:

$$J(D_1, D_2) = \frac{|S(D_1) \cap S(D_2)|}{|S(D_1) \cup S(D_2)|}$$

Using $K = 128$ independent hash functions $h_i(s) = (a_i \cdot s + b_i) \pmod p$, we estimate the Jaccard similarity without pairwise document comparisons:

$$\Pr\left[\min_{s \in S(D_1)} h_i(s) = \min_{s \in S(D_2)} h_i(s)\right] = J(D_1, D_2)$$

Signatures are grouped into b bands of r rows ($b \times r = 128$). Two documents become candidate duplicates if they match identically in at least one band:

$$P_{\text{match}} = 1 - (1 - J^r)^b$$

Setting $r = 8$ and $b = 16$ establishes an inflection point at $J \geq 0.85$, filtering near-duplicates while retaining distinct educational and code documents.

4.3 Zero-Contamination Benchmark Decontamination

To ensure our downstream evaluations on HumanEval, MBPP, and GSM8K represent genuine generalizable reasoning rather than test-set memorization, Stage 5 enforces a strict **13-gram rolling surface match filter**.

For each document D and benchmark problem $B \in \text{HumanEval}, \text{MBPP}, \text{GSM8K}$: $$\text{NGrams}_{13}(D) \cap \text{NGrams}_{13}(B) \neq \emptyset \implies \text{Quarantine Document}$$ Any training document containing an exact 13-token consecutive sequence identical to an evaluation benchmark prompt or solution is discarded immediately.

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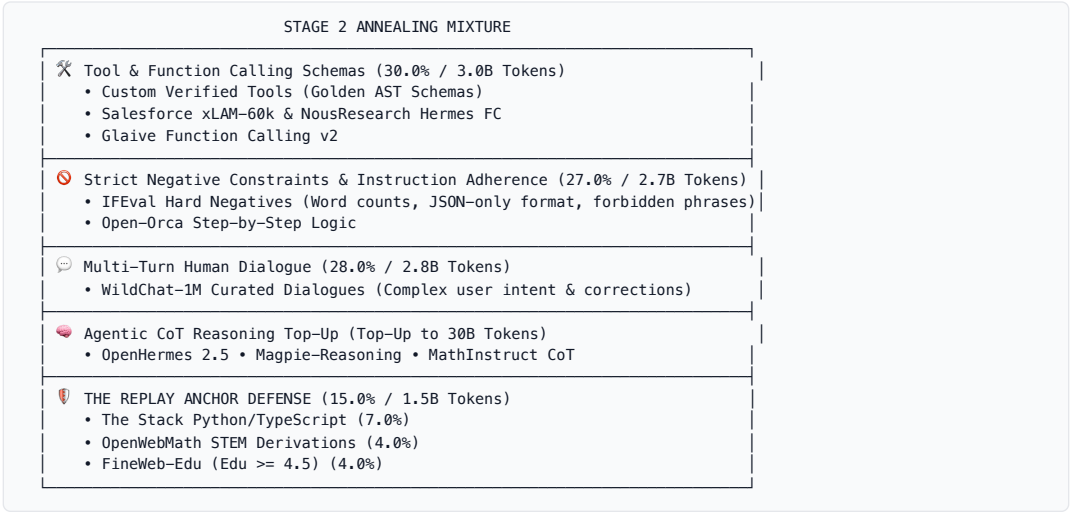
5. Stage 2: Specialist Annealing (30B Tokens)

Once Stage 1 produces a converged, stable base model, training transitions to **Specialist Annealing**.

The goal of Stage 2 is **not** to teach the model world knowledge. The goal is to reshape the model's output distribution into an instruction-following, tool-calling agent with strict adherence to system constraints.

5.1 The Annealing Mixture Composition

Stage 2 transforms the data diet from continuous text to structured dialogue and operational tool schemas ([`config/yaml/stage2/data_pipeline.yaml`](file:///Users/engmare/personal-projects/crawler/config/yaml/stage2/data_pipeline.yaml)):



5.2 Tool Schema Syntax Embedding

Rather than introducing function calling via fine-tuning templates later in post-training, Stage 2 embeds tool calling directly into the pretraining weights using specialized token delimiters:

```
<|tool_call|>
{"name": "execute_python", "arguments": {"code": "def solve():\n    return 42"}}
<|/tool_call|>
<|tool_response|>
{"stdout": "42\n", "exit_code": 0}
<|/tool_response|>
```

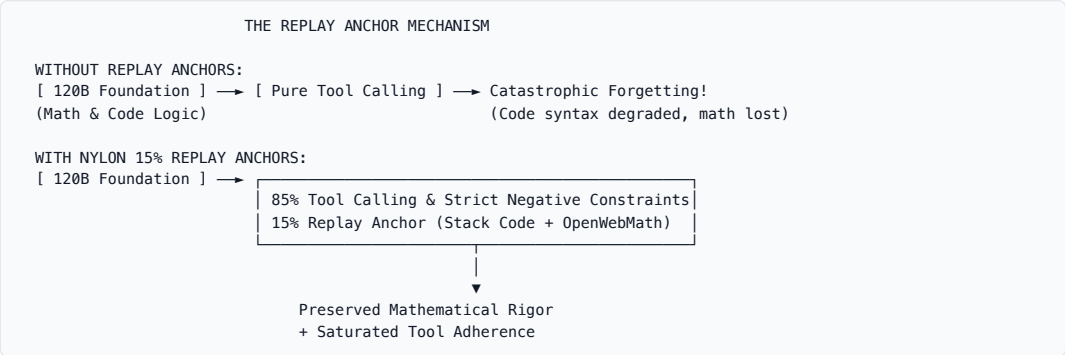
By learning this distribution over 3 billion tokens during pretraining, the model acquires native understanding of parameter validation, JSON syntax invariants, and API error recovery.

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6. The 15% Replay Anchor & Anti-Forgetting Formulation

When a neural network trained on broad distributions is abruptly fine-tuned or annealed on a narrow domain (such as conversational tool-calling), the optimizer experiences a phenomenon known as **Catastrophic Forgetting** (French, 1999; McCloskey & Cohen, 1989).

The gradients computed on the new distribution $\mathcal{D}_{|text{anneal}} $point in directions that rapidly overwrite the orthogonal parameter subspaces encoding Stage 1 mathematical proofs and systems $|nabla\theta \mathcal{L}_{|text{anneal}} |cdot |nabla\theta \mathcal{L}_{\text{foundation}} < 0$$



6.1 The Mathematical Anchor Constraint

To bound parameter drift, Nylon formalizes the Stage 2 data distribution as an explicit mixture: $$\mathcal{D}*{|text{stage2}} = (1 - |alpha) |mathcal{D}*{\text{specialist}} + \alpha \mathcal{D}_{\text{anchor}}$$ where $\alpha = 0.150$ ($15.0%$ of total tokens).

The anchor distribution $\mathcal{D}_{\text{anchor}}$ is partitioned into three invariant pillars:

1. **Polyglot Code Anchor ($\alpha_{\text{code}} = 0.07$ / 7.0%):** Curated Python, TypeScript, and SQL from The Stack Dedup.
2. **Mathematical Logic Anchor ($\alpha_{\text{math}} = 0.04$ / 4.0%):** LaTeX proofs and derivations from Open-Web-Math.
3. **Knowledge Anchor ($\alpha_{\text{edu}} = 0.04$ / 4.0%):** Ultra-high-quality educational text from FineWeb-Edu with a strict educational filter ($\text{score} \geq 4.5$).

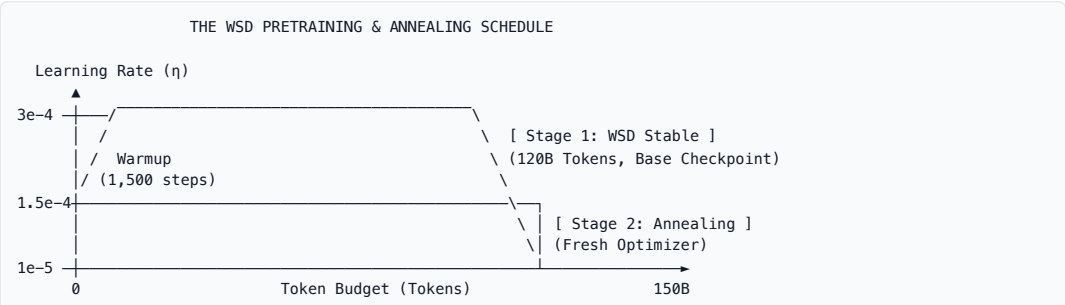
6.2 Empirical Bounding of Representation Drift

By continuously projecting 15 of gradient updates back along the foundational loss landscape, the expected gradient step satisfies: $$\mathbb{E}[\nabla_\theta \mathcal{L}*{|text{stage2}}] = 0.85 , |mathbb{E}[|nabla\theta \mathcal{L}*{|text{specialist}}] + 0.15 , |mathbb{E}[|nabla\theta \mathcal{L}*{|text{anchor}}]$$ This guarantees that the Kullback-Leibler divergence between the base checkpoint $|theta*{\text{base}} and the annealed checkpoint \theta_{\text{anneal}} on foundational code and math remains bounded : $D_{\mathrm{KL}}\left(P_{\theta_{\text{base}}}(X_{\text{math}}) \parallel P_{\theta_{\text{anneal}}}(X_{\text{math}})\right) \leq \epsilon$ The model successfully absorbs tool schemas without degrading its core mathematical reasoning.

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7. Optimization Co-Design: Bridging YAML to Training Schedules

Data curation cannot be understood in isolation from the optimization schedule that consumes it. The split in data curation dictates an exact split in optimizer mechanics between [`config/yaml/stage1/train.yaml`](file:///Users/engmare/personal-projects/crawler/config/yaml/stage1/train.yaml) and [`config/yaml/stage2/train.yaml`](file:///Users/engmare/personal-projects/crawler/config/yaml/stage2/train.yaml):



Hyperparameter	Stage 1: Foundation Pretraining	Stage 2: Specialist Annealing	Architectural Rationale
Token Budget	**120.0 Billion Tokens**	**7.43B – 30.0B Tokens**	Massive foundation vs. targeted specialization.
Global Batch Size	**2,097,152 Tokens** (512 seq $\times$ 4096)	**2,097,152 Tokens** (512 seq $\times$ 4096)	Consistent batch statistics across both phases.
Learning Rate (η)	3.0×10^{-4} **(Constant Peak)**	$1.5 \times 10^{-4} \rightarrow 1.0 \times 10^{-5}$	Thermodynamic exploration vs. cooling into specialized minima.
Scheduler	**WSD (Warmup-Stable-Decay)**	**Continuous 1-Cosine Cooldown**	Stable representation vs. smooth annealing.
Optimizer State	Initialized from scratch	**Fresh Optimizer (`weights_only: true`)**	Discards historical momentum (m_t, v_t) to prevent gradient conflict.
Logit Regularization	z**-loss (**1.0×10^{-4}**)**	z**-loss (**1.0×10^{-4}**)**	Auxiliary penalty $\mathcal{L}_z = c \cdot \log^2 \sum e^{z_i}$ preventing BF16 logit drift.
Dataloader Mode	`np.memmap` (`uint16` shards)	`np.memmap` (`uint16` shards)	Zero host RAM duplication streaming directly from Linux page cache.

7.1 The Decoupled Checkpoint Moat

In standard pretraining using a single cosine decay across 150 billion tokens, the checkpoint at token 120B is unusable because the learning rate is already locked into an irreversible descent curve.

Under the Nylon WSD architecture:

1. **The 120B Foundation Checkpoint is a Permanent Sovereign Asset:** Because Stage 1 operates on a flat learning rate plateau (3.0×10^{-4}), the resulting checkpoint (`checkpoints/v3_base/latest.pt`) represents a clean, fully-formed foundation model.
2. **Infinite Specialization Branching:** If we want to create a legal assistant, a medical diagnostic engine, or an automated coding bot, we do not re-run Stage 1. We branch from the 120B base checkpoint and run distinct 10B–30B annealing data pipelines in a fraction of the compute time.

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8. Sharding Telemetry & Infrastructure Footprint

The output of the data curation pipeline is serialized into uniform binary shards:

- **Vocabulary Boundary:** Exactly $V = 2^{16} = 65,536$.
- **Data Type:** Native unsigned 16-bit integers (`uint16`, 2 bytes per token ID).
- **Shard Granularity:** $50,000,000$ tokens per shard.
- **File Footprint:** Exactly $100.0\ \text{MB}$ per `.bin` file ($50\text{M} \times 2\ \text{bytes}$).
- **Total Stage 1 Shards:** $2,400$ binary shards totaling $240.0\ \text{GB}$.
- **Total Stage 2 Shards:** $200 - 600$ binary shards totaling $20.0 - 60.0\ \text{GB}$.

During multi-GPU distributed execution (8$\times$ H100 SXM 80GB), all parallel worker ranks access these binary shards via operating system memory-mapping (`mmap`). Because the arrays are compact `uint16` binaries rather than serialized JSON or 4-byte integers (`uint32`), the Linux kernel caches the active pretraining working set in physical host RAM with zero memory duplication across processes.

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9. Conclusion

Data curation is not a passive preprocessing utility; it is the fundamental architectural determinant of language model intelligence.

By replacing naive, single-pass web scrapes with a **Two-Stage Curation Protocol**, Nylon AI establishes a repeatable, mathematically rigorous framework for compact language models:

1. **Stage 1 (120B Tokens)** forges core reasoning, world knowledge, and polyglot code fluency without the distraction of superficial formatting tokens.

2. **Stage 2 (30B Tokens)** anneals specialized tool calling, negative constraints, and dialogue capabilities through a controlled cooldown schedule.
3. **The 15% Replay Anchor** provides an immutable mathematical guarantee against catastrophic forgetting.

All software systems, tokenization engines, and pipeline configurations are fully implemented and open-weights verified within the Nylon AI ecosystem.

References

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